11+ Creative Writing

Creative Writing Word Upgrade Dictionary

75 sophisticated replacements for everyday words, with marking guidance and technique

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

How the examiner marks your writing, a quick-reference planning method, the Show Don't Tell technique with worked examples, and 75 word upgrades across four themes: setting, movement and action, emotions, and sensory detail.

CREATIVE WRITING · SHARE WITH FAMILIES 11+ English · Word Upgrade

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How to Use This Dictionary

This guide has two layers. The first three sections cover how marks are awarded, how to plan your story, and how to write with genuine detail rather than vague statements. The remaining four sections are a working dictionary: 75 everyday phrases, each with three stronger alternatives organised by theme.

Do not try to memorise every phrase. Instead, read through each theme and mark the ten or fifteen replacements that feel most natural to you. These are the ones you will actually use under exam conditions. The goal is to have a reliable bank of precise, vivid language ready to reach for when you need it.

> *“The examiner has read 'it was dark' and 'he was scared' hundreds of times. The student who can replace both in seconds is the one who reaches the top band.”*

01 Creative Writing

How Marks Are Awarded

4 min read · Section 01 of 07

The examiner uses two separate mark schemes. Understanding both tells you exactly where word choice matters and how much it is worth.

A. CONTENT AND STYLE (20 MARKS)

The top band (19 to 20 marks) is described by examiners as writing that shows originality, flair, and a successfully controlled tone. These are not vague compliments. They are the direct result of precise word choice, deliberate sentence variety, and consistent atmosphere. Every phrase in this dictionary targets these three qualities.

| What examiners look for at the top band

- Vocabulary that is chosen deliberately, not reached for automatically.
- Consistent tone and atmosphere from the first sentence to the last.
- Emotions and scenes that are shown through sensory detail, not named directly.
- Sentence length that varies: short for impact, long for immersion.

B. GRAMMAR, SPELLING, AND PUNCTUATION (10 MARKS)

The top band (9 to 10 marks) requires spelling and grammar that are highly secure across the whole piece, with punctuation used purposefully for dramatic effect rather than simply correctly. This means using a short sentence for shock, a semicolon to link two atmospherically connected ideas, or a colon to introduce a reveal.

| Common mark-losers in this section

- Drifting between past and present tense within the same paragraph.
- Using advanced vocabulary incorrectly: one misused word destroys the impression created by ten correct ones.
- Missing commas after fronted adverbials (After a long pause, he turned.).

The single most important thing to understand

The vocabulary upgrades in this dictionary are worth marks in both sections. A precise word improves Content and Style by raising the quality of the writing. A correctly used advanced word demonstrates Technical Accuracy by showing command of language. Every upgrade earns in two places at once.

02 Creative Writing

Planning and Technique

5 min read · Section 02 of 07

Two techniques that consistently separate top-band responses from competent ones. Both can be applied to any writing task in under five minutes of preparation.

1. THE STORY MOUNTAIN (FIVE MINUTES BEFORE YOU WRITE)

Before writing a single sentence, map the four stages of your story on your planning sheet. This prevents the two most common mark-losing problems: a story that runs out of direction in the middle, and an ending that is rushed because time ran out.

- ***Introduction:*** Establish the setting and character with a strong sensory opening. Plant a hook in the very first sentence.
- ***Build-up:*** A progression of events that raises tension. Introduce a complication or a discovery.
- ***Climax:*** The peak of tension. This must feel earned by everything that came before it.
- ***Resolution:*** A meaningful conclusion. It does not need to be happy, but it must feel complete.

Define the 5 W's (Who, What, Where, When, Why) before composing the first sentence. Any inconsistency in these across the story signals a lack of control to the examiner.

Use a Circular Ending: echo the imagery or vocabulary of the opening sentence in the final sentence. This demonstrates to the examiner that the whole piece was planned in advance, which is exactly what the top band rewards.

2. SHOW, DON'T TELL

The most reliable differentiator between a proficient response and an exceptional one is this: instead of naming an emotion or describing a scene directly, build the physical and sensory evidence for it. The reader should experience the writing, not be informed by it.

| Worked examples

Telling
He was scared.

Showing
His pulse quickened, a cold sweat slicking his palms as the silence was broken by a rhythmic, metallic tapping.

Telling
The room was old.

Showing
Stagnant air, heavy with the scent of damp dust and ancient newspapers, clung to the peeling wallpaper.

Notice that neither of the showing examples names the emotion or state directly. The reader arrives at 'scared' and 'old' themselves, through the evidence. This is the precise quality that examiners describe as flair.

03 Creative Writing

Setting and Atmosphere

6 min read · Section 03 of 07

Setting descriptions are the first thing an examiner reads. These replacements give you immediate alternatives to the most overused phrases in 11+ scripts.

How to use this section

Read through the full table once and mark any phrase you would naturally reach for in a story. Those are the entries to focus on. The goal is not to memorise all twenty: it is to have five or six strong alternatives available without thinking.

SETTING AND ATMOSPHERE	
Instead of saying...	**Try one of these instead**
It was dark	1. An impenetrable gloom descended 2. Shadows swallowed the horizon 3. Draped in stygian blackness
The sun was hot	1. A relentless, scorching intensity 2. Radiating a sweltering heat 3. The midday sun was a furnace
The wind blew	1. A biting gale whipped across the moor 2. Shrieked like a wounded animal 3. A gentle zephyr rustled the leaves
It was quiet	1. A profound silence permeated the air 2. The world held its breath 3. A hushed, expectant stillness
It was loud	1. A stentorian roar erupted 2. An overwhelming cacophony 3. A deafening thunderclap fractured the silence
It was raining	1. A torrential downpour 2. Hammered against the glass with percussive force 3. A fine mist blurred reality
The sky was blue	1. An azure expanse 2. A sapphire canopy untainted by clouds 3. A cerulean vault arched overhead
The building was tall	1. An imposing, monolithic structure 2. A gargantuan needle piercing the clouds 3. A towering titan of steel
The house was old	1. An ancient, time-worn relic 2. A decrepit shell reclaimed by ivy 3. Bearing the scars of centuries
The fire was hot	1. An incandescent glow 2. An inferno radiating blistering heat 3. Embers pulsed like a dying heart

It was morning	1. Dawn broke with a pale, ethereal glow 2. First light crept over the horizon 3. An auspicious start to the day
It was night	1. Submerged in stygian ink 2. A vast, starlit void 3. Lunar silver bathed the landscape
The sea was rough	1. Churned with violent, frothing energy 2. Waves hammered the cliffs with tectonic force 3. An angry, seething mass
The forest was thick	1. An impenetrable tangle of timber 2. A dense, emerald labyrinth 3. Foliage choked the narrow path
It was snowing	1. A white shroud descended silently 2. Flurries of lace-like crystals 3. A frigid, crystalline veil
The ice was slippery	1. A treacherous, glass-like sheet 2. Movement was perilous 3. A slick veneer of frost
The path was narrow	1. A spindly trail wound precariously 2. A slender thread against the mountainside 3. A labyrinthine track through the brush
The cave was deep	1. A yawning, subterranean chasm 2. Stretching into a stygian abyss 3. A hollow void of darkness
The fog was thick	1. A dense, milky veil 2. Swallowed the landscape in a damp embrace 3. An opaque shroud over the world
The flowers were pretty	1. Radiant blooms danced 2. An iridescent tapestry of flora 3. Enchanting bursts of vibrant colour

04 Creative Writing

Character Movement and Action

6 min read · Section 04 of 07

The words walk, run, say, and look appear in almost every 11+ script. Using a precise alternative instead tells the examiner immediately that the writing is controlled and deliberate.

A note on verb choice

The verb is the engine of a sentence. Replacing a weak verb with a precise one does more for the quality of the writing than adding three adjectives. 'She trudged' contains more information and atmosphere than 'she walked very slowly and heavily'. One word does the work of six.

CHARACTER MOVEMENT AND ACTION	
Instead of saying...	**Try one of these instead**
He/She walked	1. Sauntered with ease 2. Trudged through the mire 3. Meandered through the market
He/She ran	1. Sprinted with a burst of adrenaline 2. Bolted toward the exit 3. Hurtled like a fleet-footed blur
He/She said	1. Articulated with precision 2. Interjected a warning 3. Contended that the plan was flawed
He/She looked	1. Scrutinised with narrowed eyes 2. Peered through the gloom 3. Surveyed with detached curiosity
He/She saw	1. Discerned a faint flicker 2. Glimpsed a vanishing shadow 3. Witnessed a spectacle beyond description
He/She laughed	1. A melodic chuckle escaped him 2. An irrepressible fit of giggles 3. Smirked with cynical amusement
He/She stood still	1. Remained rooted to the spot 2. Immobile as a statue 3. A silent sentinel in the dark
He/She sat down	1. Perched tentatively on the edge 2. Sank heavily into the upholstery 3. Collapsed in utter exhaustion
He/She jumped	1. Vaulted with athletic grace 2. Leaped with a reflexive burst 3. Bounded forward with intent

He/She ate	1. Consumed with voracious intent 2. Devoured the succulent fare 3. Nibbled delicately at the edges
He/She cried	1. Wept with soul-shaking grief 2. Tears cascaded like a silent river 3. Wailed in profound sorrow
He/She smiled	1. A radiant beam of joy 2. A faint, enigmatic smirk 3. An infectious, gleaming grin
He/She frowned	1. A deep furrow of concentration 2. Features contorted in a scowl 3. Glowered with cold disapproval
Breathed deeply	1. Inhaled a ragged lungful of air 2. Chest heaved with exertion 3. A shaky, shuddering breath
Loud voice	1. A stentorian boom 2. A resonant, thunderous tone 3. A vociferous command
Quiet voice	1. A hushed, conspiratorial whisper 2. A mellifluous murmur 3. An undertone of mystery
He/She was old	1. Venerable and time-worn 2. Bearing the weight of years 3. Ancient and decrepit in stature
He/She was young	1. Possessing juvenile vitality 2. In the bloom of youth 3. An inquisitive fledgling
He/She was ugly	1. Unprepossessing in appearance 2. A grotesque countenance 3. Devoid of aesthetic charm
He/She was pretty	1. Radiating breathtaking beauty 2. A pulchritudinous grace 3. Enchanting and exquisite features

05 Creative Writing

Emotions and Internal Reactions

6 min read · Section 05 of 07

Emotional description is where Show Don't Tell matters most. The alternatives in this section give you options that express the feeling through physical and behavioural evidence rather than naming it directly.

The key rule for this section

Where possible, choose the alternative that describes a physical symptom rather than the emotion itself. 'Hands turned cold and clammy' is more vivid than 'felt very nervous' because the reader feels it rather than being told it. Use the direct emotion-naming alternatives sparingly, as contrast.

EMOTIONS AND INTERNAL REACTIONS	
Instead of saying...	**Try one of these instead**
He/She was happy	1. Radiating pure elation 2. An irrepressible sense of jubilation 3. Exultant and beaming
He/She was sad	1. Etched with profound melancholy 2. Utterly desolate and forlorn 3. In a lugubrious mood
He/She was scared	1. Terror gripped his heart 2. Petrified and trembling 3. Plagued by trepidation
He/She was angry	1. Seething with barely contained rage 2. Fuming with indignation 3. An irate, explosive outburst
He/She was tired	1. Bone-weary exhaustion 2. Lethargic and drooping 3. Insurmountable fatigue
He/She was worried	1. Fretful about the outcome 2. A persistent sense of unease 3. Visibly apprehensive
He/She was surprised	1. Dumbfounded by the revelation 2. Thunderstruck and mute 3. Caught completely off-guard
He/She was nervous	1. Hands turned cold and clammy 2. Paced with restless energy 3. Visibly flustered and pale
He/She was confused	1. Completely bewildered 2. A labyrinthine state of mind 3. Looking utterly perplexed

He/She was bored	1. Trapped in monotonous apathy 2. Weary of the mundane 3. A sleep-inducing routine stretched before her
He/She was excited	1. Bubbling with effervescence 2. Thrilled by the auspicious news 3. Eager, heart-pounding anticipation
He/She was lucky	1. A moment of serendipity 2. Fortuitous and blessed 3. An auspicious turn of fate
He/She felt pain	1. A sharp pang of agony 2. Excruciating torment 3. A stinging, visceral sensation
He/She was embarrassed	1. Flushed with humiliation 2. Visibly mortified 3. A crimson tide of shame
He/She was lonely	1. A desolate state of isolation 2. Poignant solitude 3. Cut off entirely from the world
He/She was determined	1. An indomitable, resolute spirit 2. Unwavering and steadfast 3. Tenacious intent
He/She was smart	1. An astute intellect 2. An ingenious, inventive mind 3. A bright, inquisitive curiosity
He/She was mean	1. A supercilious attitude 2. A belligerent character 3. A vindictive streak
He/She was nice	1. A benevolent nature 2. An affable companion 3. A gracious, serene demeanour
He/She was brave	1. An intrepid explorer 2. A valiant spirit 3. Indomitable courage

06 Creative Writing

Sensory and Descriptive Words

5 min read · Section 06 of 07

These replacements cover the qualitative and sensory descriptions that appear throughout all story types: scale, texture, sound, light, temperature, and taste. Using precise sensory language in at least three senses is one of the markers of a top-band response.

Which senses to use

Most students default to sight alone. Top-band responses deliberately work in at least three senses. Smell is the most evocative and the most underused. A single well-chosen smell can establish an entire setting in one phrase. Touch and sound are equally powerful. Taste is best reserved for moments of acute stress or intimacy.

SENSORY AND QUALITATIVE DESCRIPTIONS	
Instead of saying...	**Try one of these instead**
It was big	1. A vast, gargantuan abyss 2. A monolithic presence 3. Colossal in physical scale
It was small	1. A miniature masterpiece 2. A tiny, shivering speck 3. Cramped and claustrophobic
The food was tasty	1. A succulent, mouth-watering feast 2. A decadent confection 3. Flavourfully complex
The smell was bad	1. A pungent, odorous stench 2. The foul scent of decay 3. An acrid, bitter aroma
The water was cold	1. A frigid, glacial expanse 2. Icily biting to the touch 3. An arctic chill
The room was messy	1. In a state of disarray 2. A cluttered repository 3. Shambolic and unkempt
It was interesting	1. Thought-provoking and gripping 2. Absolutely fascinating 3. Captivatingly unique
It was bright	1. A radiant, dazzling flash 2. Luminous and brilliant 3. Flooded with incandescent light
It was hard	1. An arduous, taxing endeavour 2. A formidable challenge 3. Gruelling and complex
It was beautiful	1. An auspicious morning unfolded 2. A sublime afternoon

	3. The weather was impeccable
High sound	1. A piercing, shrill cacophony 2. An acute, glass-shattering whistle 3. High-pitched, frantic yelps
Low sound	1. A deep, resonant thrum 2. A guttural, subterranean rumble 3. A low-frequency vibration
Rough surface	1. A jagged, abrasive texture 2. Coarse and weathered 3. Sand-papery to the touch
Smooth surface	1. A sleek, polished finish 2. Velvety and uninterrupted 3. A pristine, glossy veneer
The light was dim	1. A flickering, amber glow 2. Shrouded in weak, pallid illumination 3. The dying embers of light

07 Creative Writing

Checking Before You Finish

3 min read · Section 07 of 07

Allocate two minutes at the end of any writing assessment to run through these three checks. This is not optional: the marks available in the final check are as real as the marks available in the first sentence.

1. SENTENCE VARIETY

Read each sentence and register its length. If three or more consecutive sentences are roughly the same length, rewrite one. The deliberate alternation between short, punchy sentences and long, descriptive ones is one of the specific qualities examiners note when awarding top-band marks for style.

- Short sentences (five words or fewer) create impact and pace.
- Long sentences (twenty words or more) create immersion and atmosphere.
- A piece that uses only one type of sentence length will be marked down for syntactic variety, regardless of how good the vocabulary is.

2. PARAGRAPHING

Confirm that a new paragraph begins at every shift in: time, place, speaker, and mood. A paragraph that carries two of these shifts simultaneously is almost certainly too long and will read as structurally loose to the examiner.

- New paragraph: the scene moves to a different location.
- New paragraph: time jumps forward or backward.
- New paragraph: a different character begins speaking.
- New paragraph: the mood shifts from tension to relief, or from calm to threat.

3. FINAL VOCABULARY AND TENSE CHECK

In the final sixty seconds, scan specifically for these four things and nothing else:

- ***Tense drift:*** Check that you have not switched between past and present tense. Pick one and stay in it throughout.
- ***Weak words:*** Replace any remaining instance of 'nice', 'good', 'bad', 'said', 'walked', 'very', or 'really' with a precise alternative from this dictionary.
- ***Fronted adverbials:*** Check that any sentence beginning with an adverbial phrase (Slowly, she..., After a long pause,...) has a comma immediately after the phrase.
- ***First and last:*** Read only the opening sentence and the closing sentence. If the closing sentence echoes the opening, you have a Circular Ending. If it does not, consider whether you can add one word or phrase to create that echo.

The last thirty seconds

Do not re-read the whole piece. Read only the first sentence and the last sentence. The opening sentence sets the examiner's impression before they read anything else. The closing sentence is what they remember when they assign the final mark. These two sentences carry disproportionate weight.